

The Alder : His Story

People always knew the Alder Tree.

The agriculture specialists ignored the Alder Tree because it was a tree.

Although it was a tree, the forest specialists ignored the Alder Tree because people intercropped the tree with food grain crops.

The soil conservation specialists ignored it because they thought more of conservation of soil and not so much of creation of soil.

Of course, here and there, some agriculture specialists were interested in trees – but they were limited by their department's policy, not permitting a look at trees.

Indeed, here and there, some forest specialists were interested in trees which had sustained people for centuries, but they also were limited by their own department's policy, not permitting plantation of trees in private lands.

Also, here and there, some soil conservation specialists were interested in trees. But they, in turn, were limited by their department's programs being overwhelmingly tilted towards engineering solutions to the problem of soil erosion.

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Not only the Alder Tree, but there are nearly 1000 trees and plants which people have put to use in the past, often quite ingenious use. But these trees always fell outside the purview of the various specialisations.

Let us have a program of action in which we learn and promote what the people of Nagaland do or did with trees and crops, for so many generations, before we advise them on what to do and how to do it.

And thus, through a participatory approach, improve upon agro-forestry methods practiced in the jhum lands of Nagaland for the benefit of the people.

N E P E D

Vital Statistics

Main Project Components :

(1) Testing agro-forestry techniques with the participation of farmers.
(2) Applied Research.
(3) Training.

The role of women, as project participants, beneficiaries and decision makers is being planned and promoted.

Project Area: State of Nagaland : Seven Districts and 1000 Villages.

Project Beneficiaries: Subsistence farming families, undertaking shifting or jhum cultivation.

Project Period: Five Years (1995-2000).

Project Cost:

Total Cost - Indian Rs. 104.701 crore (C$45.522 million).

Contribution
- ICEF Rs. 12.356 crore (C$5.372 million).
- IDRC Rs. 0.805 crore (C$0.35 million).
- Nagaland Rs. 11.5 crore (C$5.0 million).
- Village Dev. Bd. Rs.75.90 crore (C$33.0 million).
- Farmers Rs. 4.140 crore (C$ 1.8 million).

Who to contact :

Further information can be obtained by contacting:

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2. The Team Leader,
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ISSUED BY PROJECT COORDINATION UNIT, IDRC, NEW DELHI

NAGALAND ENVIRONMENT PROTECTION AND ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT PROJECT

NEPED



Putting the People First

Sustainable livelihood, environment protection and development, by putting rural people first, are the principal themes underlying NEPED. The project goal is sustainable management of the natural resource base for the benefit of the people of Nagaland. It focuses on environment conservation and improved management of natural resources through searching for and finding improved agro-forestry practices. The project is specifically designed to introduce improvements in land under jhum (slash & burn or shifting) cultivation. An agro-forestry approach of planting firewood and timber trees with food grain and vegetable crops will be tested and demonstrated by the farmers. Such an approach is expected not only to promote bio-diversity but increase soil fertility and reduce soil erosion, which will increase crop yield. In addition, the mature trees, nurtured in the jhum plots, will provide cash income for the farming families.

The agro-forestry practices, thus introduced, will contribute to

– conservation of the natural forest land from being encroached upon by jhum cultivation;

and

– transform, through demonstration, a major portion of the land, currently under jhum, into land in which agro-forestry techniques will be applied. This, in turn, will make the shifting cultivation practices more productive and profitable.

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A Participatory Approach

The project operation follows a participatory approach and, through PRA (Participatory Rural Appraisal), involves the jhum farming families in planning the jhum cycle and in selecting the crops and intercropping patterns and the plant and tree species to be adopted under the agro-forestry approach.

This project has been designed to address the cultural sensitivity and acceptability of the very distinct Naga tribes. The concept of agro-forestry is not alien to Nagaland. The current jhuming practice itself is a form of agro-forestry, all be it unplanned and thus less profitable and sustainable. The project will only introduce more planned interventions. Since the concept introduced is not entirely new, the cultural acceptability of the agro-forestry techniques and packages, introduced through the medium of the project, is expected to be high.

The district and village based organizations in Nagaland are fairly strong and they plan and implement projects through collective decisions. These organizations will serve to motivate the farmers in adopting the techniques proposed. As the project evolves, through adoption by farmers of various measures and packages to be practiced in their jhum lands, the village organizations (Village Development Boards-VDBs) would invest their own community development funds to replicate the practices tested in the jhum plots under the project. The replication activities will serve as one of the measures of success of the project while ensuring the sustainability of its impact.



Centres of Responsibility

At the Nagaland state level, the project is coordinated by a Project Operation Unit (POU) and steered by a Project Steering Committee. At the district and village levels, the existing local organizations, the District Planning Boards and the Village Development Councils and Boards will supervise the project operation. The technical personnel, drawn from different disciplines, who are currently members of the District Planning Boards and the specialists with the POU, will provide the technical assistance required.

IDRC serves as the project coordination agency and undertakes monitoring and capacity building tasks on behalf of the donors of the project, through a small Unit or Secretariat established in its representative office in New Delhi. The project is jointly funded by the Governments of India and Canada (CIDA). The funding mechanism for the project is the India-Canada Environment Facility (ICEF), which finances environment projects in India from the counterpart funds generated from the sale proceeds of commodities gifted to India by CIDA, under Canadian Government's development cooperation program.

